

IDEOLOGICAL BATTLES A still from Rajkumar Santoshi's *Gandhi Godse–Ek Yudh*

For **RAJKUMAR SANTOSHI,** it is a matter of shame that "we haven't made more films on" Gandhi

(2003 and 2006) films, which made 'Gandhigiri' fashionable.

Where Santoshi's film differs from them is that it sees Gandhi in the context of Nathuram Godse, who is given equal billing. Working on a what-if scenario, wherein Gandhi survives the assassination, the drama starts with Godse expressing his frustration over Partition and explaining his worldview. "His [Godse's] voice was suppressed," says Santoshi. "The statement he gave in court, you may agree or disagree with it, like it or not like it, but it has to be heard. I am not justifying his actions. Who am I to? He was, after all, punished." By reimagining history, Santoshi and his co-writer Asghar Wajahat hope to spur discussion or debate. "It is my most difficult film yet—*talwar ke dhaar par chalne waali baat hai* [it's akin to walking on a sword's edge]," says Santoshi.

Another filmmaker to have cast his lens on Gandhi by depicting him through the eyes of his eldest son is Feroz Abbas Khan, who made *Gandhi, My Father* (2007). Based on Chandulal Dalal's *Harilal Gandhi: Ek Dukhad Atma*, the film didn't put Gandhi on a pedestal, but it didn't pull him down either as it showed his lesser-known side—that of a "failed father". Khan says, "It wasn't about one part being right or wrong.... They are victims of circumstances and time in history. That's where the dilemma was. If you want to fight against injustice, sacrifice has to be made. In this case, they happened to be your dear one."

The wariness to make a film on Gandhi, says Khan, stems from the fact that he isn't seen as a box-office darling. "There seems to be an understanding that the moment you talk about Gandhi, the audience doesn't want to watch [a film on him] because they feel they are going to get a whole lot of moral lessons," says Khan. There's also a sense of familiarity with Gandhi given how pivotal a part he plays in history books. That necessitates more cinematic narratives around the legend, feels Khan. "The way we have been introduced to Gandhi is extremely benign, so perfect and also old. It almost makes him boring and so impossible for the younger generation," adds Khan. "Then, there is a Gandhi you want to denigrate and demolish."

Santoshi is mindful of these detractors; many of them left comments on his film's trailer online, vilifying Gandhi and praising Godse. But the director is clear that the man's contribution to the freedom struggle is unparalleled. "The work he has done for the nation in his lifetime, *uske ungli ke baraabar humne nahin kiya* [what we've done is nothing compared to his contribution]," he says. "What moral right do we have to criticise or abuse him?"

Gandhi may not be physically present in our stories, but his ideology continues to inspire creators. "If someone is raising a voice against injustice, asking for compassion or asking for freedom, that's being Gandhian. He is no more a person; he is an idea too entrenched in the collective decency and consciousness of this country to be erased," says Khan. ■

Suhani Singh

WATCHLIST

HOMESPUN GANDHI



GANDHI, MY FATHER
2007
(Eros Now)
The drama shows the strained relationship between Mahatma Gandhi (Darshan Jariwala) and his eldest son, Harilal (Akshaye Khanna), and the struggles of the latter to carve a path of his own.



HEY RAM
2000
(JioCinema, Amazon Prime Video)
After his wife is killed in a riot, Saket Ram (Kamal Haasan) blames Gandhi (Naseeruddin Shah) for the division of India and plots to kill him. But he gradually course-corrects after meeting the man himself.

THE MAKING OF THE MAHATMA
1996
(YouTube)
Shyam Benegal focuses on Gandhi's (played by Rajit Kapur) formative years as a barrister in South Africa and how they strengthened his resolve to free India from colonial rule.

